

Wondering how good you are at something no one's ever graded

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

There's no scoreboard for this, so all you have is your own sense of it, and that sense **runs kinder on you than the truth does**, which makes it tempting never to check.

THE GOAL

You're trying to find out whether you can trust that feeling, not confirm it. Pick one thing you did recently and get a real, outside read on it.

CHECKLIST

Right after you finish doing the thing and catch yourself wondering how it actually went.

- ☐ Close out whatever's still open from what you just did, like ending the call or parking the car, before you start judging how it went.
- ☐ Name one exact thing that happened, not the overall feeling, like the line you fumbled or the point you nailed.
- ☐ If this gives you a clear pass-or-fail result each time, like a score or an error count, **check that number** now, not the vibe.
- ☐ If it doesn't give you a result like that, pick one person who was actually there, not the first person you happen to run into.
- ☐ Ask that person about one specific moment, like "how did the part where I lost the thread land?", not "how did I do?"
- ☐ Write down what they say close to their own words, before you soften it into something kinder or harsher.
- ☐ Treat that answer as **one data point**, not a verdict, and get a second read before changing your mind.
- ☐ Compare what they said to what you assumed walking in, and say the gap out loud in one sentence.
- ☐ If the answer stings, write down the one thing you'd actually try differently next time, not how the comment made you feel.
- ☐ If all you got was something vague, like "you did fine," ask one narrower follow-up right then instead of letting it drop.
- ☐ If you keep a personal tally for this, add today's attempt to it before you forget the exact number.
- ☐ Put the exact detail you named and whatever you just learned **somewhere you'll actually run into** before you do this next.
- ☐ Before you move on, say plainly whether you're going on a real detail and an outside read, or just on the vibe again.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Your gut only tracks how good you actually are **moderately well**. It isn't proof either way.
- 2 When positive feedback made you feel surer of yourself than the task really warranted, you tended to skip double-checking your answer.
- 3 A coworker and a supervisor who watch you tend to rate you closely in line with each other. Your own view **is the outlier**.

How closely your own sense tracks reality

KNOW

Your gut only tracks how good you actually are **moderately well**. It isn't proof either way.

The gap holds up across academic work, sports, and job performance alike, not a single narrow case. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Your gut is only as good as the feedback the skill gives you.

Self-ratings lined up with reality far more on familiar, objective, low-complexity tasks than on broad, fuzzy ones. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Time on the job only moderately lines up with real performance.

A pooled review of tens of thousands of workers found only a moderate link between time served and results. [Source 2](#)

DO

Count how many times you've actually done this exact thing.

Tallying actual repetitions lined up with performance much better than tallying years in the role. [Source 2](#)

Why it leans the way it does

KNOW

You tend to **credit something lasting about yourself** when things go well, and blame the situation when they don't.

The pattern showed up strongly, in nearly every group of people studied, not just a self-conscious few. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

When positive feedback made you feel surer of yourself than the task really warranted, you tended to skip double-checking your answer.

A second version of the same test, where confidence came from an easier task instead of feedback, didn't produce the same drop in checking. [Source 4](#)

What another person's read is actually worth

KNOW

A coworker and a supervisor who watch you tend to rate you closely in line with each other. Your own view **is the outlier**.

Independent outside readings of you tend to agree with each other, and that's exactly what your own reading skips. [Source 5](#)

WATCH

A trained opinion still only gives you a partial read.

Supervisors rating the same person's overall work landed only in the **moderate** range of agreement with each other. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you were bad at something, you'd sense it: the least skilled people are famously the ones who lack the skill to see their own incompetence.

ACTUALLY

A test-based version of this claim sorted people by score **without separating out plain bad luck** on the test. Correcting for that flipped the pattern: the highest performers showed the most overconfidence, not the least skilled. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.psychologicalscience.org/journals/perspectives/1745691613518075/>
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Judging your own progress at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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